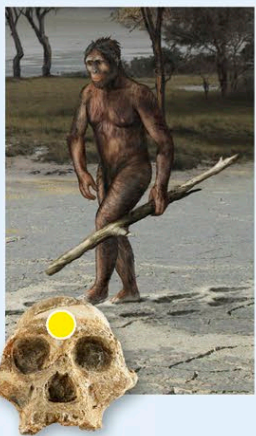


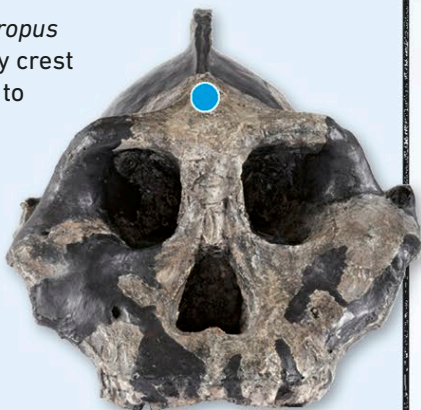
Australopithecus



Australopithecus hominins evolved about 4.2 million years ago in east Africa. Six species are known. One species, called *A. afarensis*, may be the ancestor of humans. Fossils show that it was up to 5 ft (1.5 m) tall and had a relatively small brain. Crucially, it could walk upright.

Paranthropus

The three *Paranthropus* species had a bony crest on top of the skull to anchor strong chewing muscles. *P. boisei* is nicknamed "nutcracker man" because of its massive jaws and cheek teeth.



Neander Valley, Germany

A partial skeleton of *H. neanderthalensis* found in a cave here in 1856 was the first fossil to be identified as human remains.

Fossil humans

Fossil discoveries have helped scientists to piece together the story of human evolution. Modern humans—*Homo sapiens*—and their ancestors are called hominins. *Sahelanthropus tchadensis*, the first hominin, was an apelike animal that appeared in Africa about 7 million years ago. Later hominin species left Africa and spread out around the world.

Laetoli, Tanzania
Footprints of at least two *Australopithecus afarensis* individuals were discovered here, preserved in volcanic ash.

Olduvai Gorge, Tanzania
Stone tools and fossils of *P. boisei* and *H. habilis* were found here.

South Africa
Finds include *Australopithecus*, *Paranthropus*, *H. habilis*, and *H. sapiens* fossils.

Apelike
Australopithecus—
six species

4 million years ago 3